iPhone Duo fixes Apple's missing halo tier

Minutes after John Ternus revealed a ₹3 lakh iPhone at the Steve Jobs Theater, I was lined up to interview AP Dhillon. Mid-way, some fans spotted him and asked for selfies.

The strategy for the Duo hit me then.

Look at the room: *AP in high-fashion designer gear, me in an outfit I've recycled for twenty events, and fans in denim and tees.*

What did all three have in common? All were holding an orange iPhone 17 Pro Max.

For a long time, the iPhone was the ultimate democratic product. You could buy a luxury car, luxury clothes, or a luxury house but you couldn't buy a "more expensive" iPhone than the person sitting next to you. The Pro Max was the ceiling for everyone.

When the iPhone Duo hits the shelves, Apple officially reinstates the luxury gap.

The iPhone Duo is not just Apple joining the foldable race. It is Apple establishing an entirely new ultra-premium tier above the Pro Max. Evaluating it purely through traditional smartphone metrics misses the point. The Duo is a halo product aimed at pulling a select segment of Apple's premium installed base higher into the luxury tech realm.

On paper, the Duo carries significant weight. In reality, Apple's attention to weight distribution transforms the physical experience. During the few minutes I spent with the phone, it felt surprisingly balanced. The center of mass is calibrated so that whether held one-handed while folded or opened wide with both hands, it avoids feeling top-heavy.

The custom hinge offers precise friction throughout its movement. It holds its angle reliably across multiple positions, transforming the device into its own stand for video conferencing, long-exposure photography, and media playback. Apple has a matte nano-texture finish on the inner display. This optical coating cuts down reflections and visually minimises the crease beneath the flexible glass, delivering an uninterrupted canvas.

It's actually amazing. I have used more than a dozen foldable phones in the last 7 years and nothing comes close to what Apple has achieved with that screen in the first attempt.

Beyond the display aesthetics, the device offers solid hardware. The under-display internal camera handles casual calls smoothly without disrupting content playback. Complemented by spatial speakers that dynamically adjust their EQ and acoustic soundstage based on orientation, the hardware feels cohesive right out of the gate.

Many hardware features seen on the Duo exist across the broader foldable market. What distinguishes Apple's approach is the lack of friction in use. Rather than forcing users to adapt to an unfamiliar interface, the iPhone Duo minimises behavioral overhead.

There are millions of iOS users who found foldable hardware intriguing over the years but refused to leave the Apple ecosystem. The Duo eliminates that dilemma.



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Manas Tiwari
Editor

The pricing game

A ₹3 lakh price point naturally narrows the initial buyer pool, but at this tier, price itself functions as a feature. In mature urban markets, smartphones have achieved ubiquitous status. Even top-tier flagship devices blend into the daily. The Duo restores immediate recognisability and distinction.

This strategy aligns directly with broader economic shifts in key markets like India. The Average Selling Price of smartphones has jumped. Consumers are purchasing fewer devices, but investing significantly in premium hardware that offers distinct value or status.

The iPhone Duo is positioned to redefine expectations for book-style foldables. While remaining a specialised option within Apple's broader lineup, its combination of familiar software, refined hardware, and status appeal gives it strong momentum.

In its inaugural year, Apple's primary operational challenge may not be generating demand, but managing product supply.

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